# Gandhi's Autobiography

## By Buddy Wakefield

## INTRODUCTION

*We all say it: "I'm only human," and yet we continually get down on ourselves for making mistakes. So what exactly is human imperfection and why are we both comforted by it and constantly trying to make it disappear? Is human imperfection simply the number of mistakes made multiplied by the size of the mistake or is it really the lesson that's important? As children we learn by making mistakes. We touch a hot stove and remember not to do it again or we go through experiences with different people and learn from those mistakes how to react in certain situations. The size of the mistake or impact on our life tends to leave different impressions on each of us that cause us to react or think in a certain way whenever we encounter these situations again. It can be as simple as looking both ways before crossing to being terrified every time you cross the street. The mistakes we've made have a profound effect on each of us, but do we have to live our lives as if we are defined by our mistakes? Of course not, but people do it every day. Hey, nobody's perfect. Not even Mahatma Gandhi. Gandhi's Autobiography by Buddy Wakefield.*

Gandhi's autobiography is on my pillow.

I put it there every morning after making my bed

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so I'll remember to read it before falling asleep.

I've been reading it for 6 years.

I'm on Chapter 2.

Gary Necci gave me a book when he left my house one time.

I don't remember the title of it exactly

but I think it was called something like

"Kid, You Are Seriously Co-dependent."

He thought I might wanna flip through and learn about that.

I feel like it's more important to finish Gandhi's autobiography first.

I keep forgetting to put *focus* on my to-do list.

I keep forgetting to wander and have fun.

I know I'm transparent

but my insecurities are in all the right places

so go ahead

have a look.

When I was a child I would chase my babysitter around the house

viscerally sounding out the end of the letter "L".

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lllllllllLLL

. . . llllll

Have another look.

When will we own ourselves completely?

Tell me what it is you want me to own

and I will take it.

Damaged goods?

You bet

Hit or miss?

No doubt about it.

Misses important social cues?

Yes,

I do.

I am dirty underneath the light

Pale on the backside of my bright

and feel a little bit stupid about learning a language

when I see God

because that guy . . .

so fast.

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My best friend can speak six languages.

I still get excited that English took hold.

Sometimes I don't feel like I'm doing my part on this planet.

Sometimes I read without paying attention

hoping everything will just sorta sink in so that

if I ever need the answers -- like on a test --

my subconscious will somehow pull through for me.

I talk too much.

If you see me being quiet

don't ask what's wrong.

I'm just practicing.

I often wonder if anyone died because of

the pencil I handed to a prisoner at San Quentin.

He stuck it in his pocket.

The point is:

there are things wrong with us.

There are things wrong with me.

But I do have the ability to split epiphanies with my face on demand.

Hold me like a birthmark,

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awkward if you have to.

I wander,

so if you lose me,

don't worry.

After the big tsunami

the only structure still standing in the wiped-out village

of Malacca

was a statue of Mahatma Gandhi.

I wanna be able to stand like that.

Even after getting gargled and spanked

and spit out by God,

I wanna know that I don't have to fall

every time the sky opens up like a coin return

to change me

with its pudgy black fingers

tracing lines on maps

drawing circles around my blood

to show the scars here

in the shape of Gandhi on my pillow,

to show that I have been here before

and this is *not* the last time I've seen the light.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Buddy Wakefield***
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## AWARD HISTORY

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